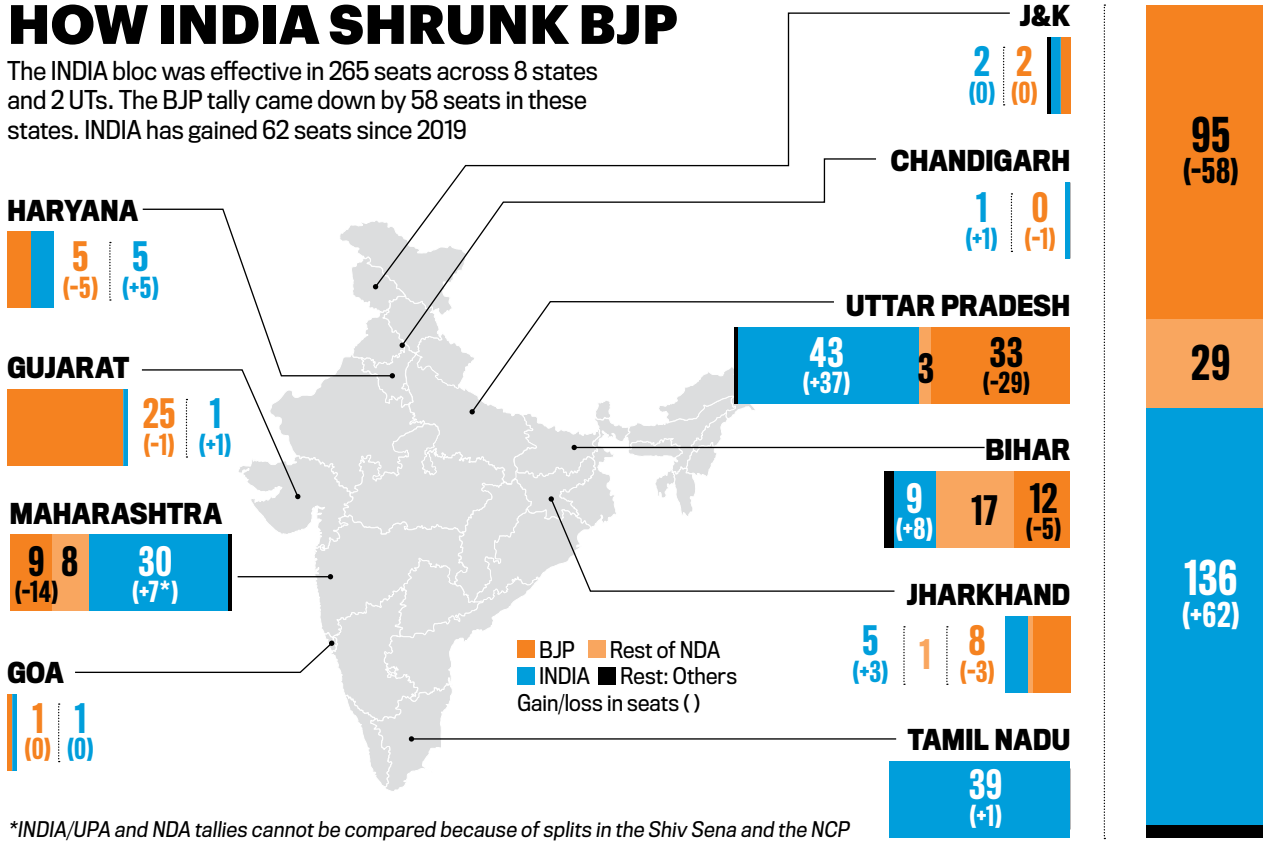
HOW INDIA SHRUNK BJP

The INDIA bloc was effective in 265 seats across 8 states and 2 UTs. The BJP tally came down by 58 seats in these states. INDIA has gained 62 seats since 2019



*INDIA/UPA and NDA tallies cannot be compared because of splits in the Shiv Sena and the NCP

THE MAHA SURPRISE

And the Congress believes this new image of Rahul has begun bearing fruit. As evidence, they point to all the states BJY covered. Barring Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh, the Congress tally has either risen or sustained in all states. It has emerged as the leading player in Maharashtra, despite top leaders deserting it. The Congress won 13 of the 17 seats it contested here—15 of them against the BJP. A higher strike rate than that of ally Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), which won nine out of 21. In fact, across India, of the 164 seats where the Congress faced off with the BJP, it won 38, a vast step up from the 15 it won out of the 190 such seats in 2019.

Maharashtra, where INDIA won a conclusive 30 of 48 seats, also offers testimony to how the Congress tapped into rural distress. The party won in all the rural constituencies the BJY passed through. The GOP has, in fact, improved its tally in the country's rural seats—from 29 in 2019 to 55 this time—even though it's no match to the BJP's tally of 149 seats.

Though the Opposition won the minority vote, over-reliance can leave them open to the accusation of appeasement

But all this joy could also be short-lived, particularly in the Maharashtra assembly polls later this year, if INDIA fails to put up a united fight against the NDA. There is still no clarity on which Sena has the bigger mandate. If SS(UBT) won nine seats, the Shinde faction won seven of the 15 seats it fought—including six in direct shoot-outs with SS(UBT), which won seven of those. Things are more definitive in the case of the two factions of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Only one of the four candidates of the Ajit Pawar faction won while the NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) won eight of the 10 seats it fought. But with the Congress making the most gains, there are also murmurs in the Sena camp about the long-term utility of the partnership, particularly as it's no longer the biggest party in the Maha Vikas Aghadi. Meanwhile, Pawar Sr, who was contemplating merging his party with the Congress, may put his plans on hold following a superlative performance.

THE CASTE CHEMISTRY

A chief pillar of Rahul's social justice formula was the idea of a caste census, even if it originally came from Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal (United) patriarch Nitish Kumar, who subsequently switched sides. At the core of this assertion of *jitni aabadi utna haq* or proportional representation is the strategy to wean away the OBCs, Dalits and tribals from the BJP. UP and Bihar seem to have responded to this strategy, as the GOP teamed up with the leading regional parties in these states, the Rashtriya Janata Dal and the Samajwadi Party. Both parties have traditionally relied heavily on Yadavs and Muslims, alienating them from other caste groups. To amend